

"Put your hands to work and give your hearts to God."

MOTHER ANN LEE, FOUNDER OF THE SHAKER MOVEMENT,
AS QUOTED BY CHARLES NORDHOFF, 1875

THE SHAKER MOVEMENT

The Shakers (a name given to the United Society of Believers in Christ's Second Appearing due to their euphoric practices of worship) are a Protestant sect that was brought to the US in the 18th century by British immigrant Mother Ann Lee. She formed the first congregation in Albany, New York, in the 1770s, and the movement flourished into the mid-19th century before it began to decline. The sect lived a communal life, and emphasized hard work, simple living, and celibacy. Shaker communities also believed in duality—that God was both male and female—and their doctrine therefore promoted the equality of the sexes. Shaker men and women engaged in set dances (one depicted right, in an 1870's woodcut) such as the "Square Order Shuffle" and the "Quick Step Manner" in order to receive the "gift"—prophetic powers or the ability to heal diseases.

